The Secret Life of Walter Mitty

By James Thurber

DAYDREAM #1

(Somewhere in a Navy hydroplane in a winter storm)

COMMANDER: We're going through!

NARRATOR: The Commander's voice was like thin ice breaking. He wore his full-dress uniform, with the heavily braided white cap pulled down rakishly over one cold gray eye.

LTN BERG: We can't make it, sir. It's spoiling for a hurricane, if you ask me.

COMMANDER: I'm not asking you, Lieutenant Berg. Throw on the power lights! Rev her up to 8500! We're going through!

NARRATOR: The pounding of the cylinders increased *(ta-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa)*

COMMANDER: *(twisting a row of dials, shouting)* Switch on No. 8 auxiliary! Full strength in No. 3 turret!

LTN BERG: No. 8 auxiliary! Full strength in No. 3 turret! The Old Man'll get us through. The Old Man ain't afraid of hell!

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INTRODUCTION

Ever wish you could escape the crushing responsibility of remembering grocery lists, making small talk, or figuring out why you walked into a room… and instead enter a world where you are always the main character?

A world where every decision is bold, every line is dramatic, and no one ever asks, "Did you remember the puppy biscuits?" (harumph) Obviously, you're too busy saving lives, winning battles, and looking incredibly cool while doing it.

For octogenarian Walter Mitty reality is optional, heroism is guaranteed, and the only real danger is getting snapped back to the boring real world at the worst possible moments.

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NARRATOR: The pounding of the cylinders increased *(ta-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa. Walter is immersed in his daydream)*

REALITY

MRS. MITTY: Not so fast! You're driving too fast! What are you driving so fast for?

WALTER: Hmm?

NARRATOR: He looked at his wife, in the seat beside him, with shocked astonishment. She seemed grossly

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unfamiliar, like a strange woman who had yelled at him in a crowd. **MRS. MITTY:** You were up to 55. You know I don't like to go more than 40. You were up to 55.

NARRATOR: Walter Mitty drove on in silence, the roaring of the SN202 through the worst storm in 20 years of Navy flying fading in the airways of his mind.

MRS. MITTY: You're tensed up again. It's one of your days. I wish you'd let Dr. Renshaw look you over.

NARRATOR: Walter Mitty stopped the car in front of the building where his wife went to have her hair done.

MRS. MITTY: Remember to get those overshoes while I'm having my hair done.

WALTER: I don't need overshoes.

MRS. MITTY: *(arranging things in her handbag)* We've been all through that. *(getting out of the car)* You're not a young man any longer.

WALTER: *(races the engine a little - ta-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa)*

MRS. MITTY: Why don't you wear your gloves? Have you lost your gloves? *(Walter reaches in a pocket; brings out the gloves and puts them on)*

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NARRATOR: But after she had turned and gone into the building and he had driven on to a red light, he took them off again. He drove around the streets aimlessly for a time, and then he drove past the hospital.

DAYDREAM #2

NURSE: It's the millionaire banker, Wellington McMillan.

WALTER: *(removing his gloves slowly)* Yes? Who has the case?

NURSE: Dr. Renshaw and Dr. Benbow, but there are two specialists here, Dr. Remington from New York and Dr. Pritchard-Mitford from London. He flew over.

DR. RENSHAW: *(entering, looking distraught and haggard)* Hello, Mitty. We're having the devil's own time with McMillan, the millionaire banker and close personal friend of Roosevelt. Obstreosis of the ductal tract. Wish you'd take a look at him.

NARRATOR: In the operating room there were whispered introductions.

DR. RENSHAW: Dr. Remington, Dr. Mitty. Dr. Pritchard-Mitford, Dr. Mitty.

DR. P-M: *(shaking Walter's hand)* I've read your book on streptothricosis. A brilliant performance, sir.

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NARRATOR: A huge, complicated machine, connected to the operating table began at this moment to go *(pocketa-pocketa-queep-pocketa-queep)*

INTERN: The new anesthetizer is giving away! There is no one in the East who knows how to fix it!

WALKER: *(in a low cool voice)* Quiet, man! *(moving dials on the machine)* Give me a fountain pen! *(he pulls a faulty piston from the machine and inserts the pen)* That will hold for 10 minutes. Get on with the operation.

NARRATOR: A nurse hurried over and whispered to Renshaw, and Mitty saw the man turn pale.

DR. RENSHAW: *(nervously)* Coreopsis has set in. If you would take over, Mitty?

NARRATOR: Mitty looked at him and at the uncertain faces of the two great specialists.

WALTER: If you wish. *(he dons a surgical gown, adjust a mask and pulls on thin latex gloves)*

REALITY

PARKING LOT ATTENDANT: Back it up, Mac!! Look out for that Buick! *(Walter jams on the breaks in a panic)* Wrong lane, Mac.

WALTER: Gee. Yeh.

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NARRATOR: He began cautiously to back out of the lane marked "Exit Only."

PARKING LOT ATTENDANT: Leave her sit there. I'll put her away. *(Walter gets out of the car)* Hey, better leave the key.

WALTER: Oh . . . *(handing the man the ignition key)*

NARRATOR: The attendant vaulted into the car, backed it up with insolent skill, and put it where it belonged.

WALTER: *(he walks away muttering)* They're so damn cocky, They think they know everything.

NARRATOR: Once he had tried to take his chains off, outside New Milford, and he had got them wound around the axles. A man had had to come out in a wrecking car and unwind them, a young, grinning garage man. Since then Mrs. Mitty always made him drive to a garage to have the chains taken off.

WALTER: The next time, I'll wear my right arm in a sling; they won't grin at me then. I'll have my right arm in a sling and they'll see I couldn't possibly take the chains off myself. *(kicks at something on the sidewalk as he remembers his task)* Overshoes.

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NARRATOR: When he came out into the street again, with the overshoes in a box under his arm, Walter Mitty began to wonder what the other thing was his wife had told him to get. She had told him twice before they set out from their house. In a way he hated these weekly trips to town--he was always getting something wrong.

WALTER: Kleenex? No. Razor blades? No. Tooth paste?

NARRATOR: He gave it up. But she would remember it.

WALTER: *(mimicking Mrs. Mitty)* Where's the what's-its-name.

NARRATOR: A newsboy went by shouting something about the Waterbury trial.

DAYDREAM #3

DISTRICT ATTORNEY: *(holding out an automatic gun to the person on the witness stand)* Perhaps this will refresh your memory. Have you ever seen this before?

WALTER: *(takes the gun and examines it expertly, then calmly)* This is my Webley-Vickers 50.80.

NARRATOR: An excited buzz ran around the courtroom. The Judge rapped for order.

DISTRICT ATTORNEY: You are a crack shot with any sort of firearms, I believe?

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MITTY'S ATTORNEY: Objection! We have shown that the defendant could not have fired the shot. We have shown that he wore his right arm in a sling on the night of the 14th of July.

WALTER: *(raises his hand and the bickering attorneys are stilled)* With any known make of gun, I could have killed Gregory Fitzhurst at three hundred feet with my left hand.

NARRATOR: Pandemonium broke loose in the courtroom. A woman's scream rose above the bedlam and suddenly a lovely, dark-haired girl was in Walter Mitty's arms. The District Attorney struck at her savagely.

WALTER: *(lets the DA have it on the point of his chin)* You miserable cur! *(the word "cur" brings him back to reality)*

REALITY

WALTER: Puppy biscuit. . .

PASSING WOMAN: *(laughs)* He said "Puppy biscuit." That man said "Puppy biscuit" to himself.

NARRATOR: Walter Mitty hurried on. He went into an A&P.

WALTER: I want some biscuit for small, young dogs.

CLERK: Any special brand, sir?

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NARRATOR: The greatest pistol shot in the world thought a moment . . .

WALTER: It says 'Puppies Bark for It' on the box. *(looks at his watch)*

NARRATOR: His wife would be through at the hairdresser's in fifteen minutes. She didn't like to get to the hotel first, she would want him to be there waiting for her as usual. He found a big leather chair in the lobby, facing a window, and he put the overshoes and the puppy biscuit on the floor beside it. He picked up an old copy of Liberty and sank down into the chair.

WALTER: *(reading a headline)* Can Germany Conquer the World Through the Air?

DAYDREAM #4

SERGEANT: The cannonading has got the wind up in young Raleigh, sir.

CAPTAIN MITTY: *(wearily)* Get him to bed with the others. I'll fly alone.

SERGEANT: *(anxiously)* But you can't, sir. It takes two men to handle that bomber and the Archies are pounding the hell out of the air. Von Richtman's circus is between here and Saulier.

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WALTER: Somebody's got to get that ammunition dump. I'm going over. *(pours a drink)* Spot of brandy?

NARRATOR: War thundered and whined around the dugout and battered at the door. There was a rending of wood and splinters flew through the room.

WALTER: *(barely flinching)* A bit of a near thing.

SERGEANT: The box barrage is closing in!

WALTER: *(with a faint fleeting smile)* We only live once, Sergeant . . . Or do we? *(pours another shot and throws it back)*

SERGEANT: I've never seen a man could hold his brandy like you, sir. *(Mitty straps on his huge Webley-Vickers automatic)* Begging your pardon, sir. It's 40 kilometers through hell, sir.

WALTER: *(finishes one last brandy, speak softly)* After all, what isn't?

NARRATOR: The pounding of the cannon increased; there was the rat-tat-tatting of machine guns, and from somewhere came the menacing *(ta-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa-pocketa)* of the new flame-throwers.

REALITY

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MRS. MITTY: *(striking Walter on the shoulder)* I've been looking all over this hotel for you. Why do you have to hide in this old chair? How did you expect me to find you?

WALTER: *(vaguely)* Things close in . . .

MRS. MITTY: What? Did you get the what's-its-name? The puppy biscuit? What's in that box?

WALTER: Overshoes.

MRS. MITTY: Couldn't you have put them on in the store?

WALTER: *(protesting weakly)* I was thinking. Does it ever occur to you that I am sometimes thinking?

MRS. MITTY: I'm going to take your temperature when I get you home.

NARRATOR: They went out through the revolving doors that made a faintly derisive whistling sound when you pushed them. It was two blocks to the parking lot. At the drugstore on the corner . . .

MRS. MITTY: Wait here for me. I forgot something. I won't be a minute.

NARRATOR: She was more than a minute.

WALTER: *(lighting a cigarette, he leans against the wall of the drugstore, smoking)*

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DAYDREAM #5

WALTER: *(putting his shoulders back and his heels together, he says scornfully)* To hell with the handkerchief! *(takes one last drag on the cigarette and snaps it away)*

NARRATOR: Then, with that faint, fleeting smile playing about his lips, he faced the firing squad; erect and motionless, proud and disdainful, Walter Mitty the Undefeated, inscrutable to the last.

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AWARD HISTORY

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